the afternoon of 27 October, the V-bombers were held at Cockpit Alert (05 readiness) with pilots waiting to turn on their engines and scramble.[15]

The scale of Western nuclear preparations during the Cuban missile crisis was unsurpassed during the Cold War (and beyond). The ICBMs would have reached their targets in half an hour or so; the SLBMs and IRBMs would have taken fifteen to twenty minutes. From their Fail-Safe points, the B-52s were two hours' flying time from their targets. Once the ICBMs, SLBMs, and IRBMs were launched, they could not be recalled. In October 1962 the United States possessed 27,387 nuclear weapons, the Soviet Union, 3,322 and the United Kingdom over 200. France had tested an atomic device in 1960, but in 1962 seems not to have yet deployed nuclear weapons At the peak of the missile crisis it is estimated that the US had some 3,500 nuclear warheads and bombs ready for use and the Soviets some 300-500.[16] The British had over a hundred, which did not include the Thor IRBMs. Like the Jupiters in Italy and Turkey, these operated on 'a dual-key' system whereby the host nation controlled the missile and US personnel were responsible for the warhead.

The atomic bombs dropped on Japan in 1945 were measured in kilotons; each kiloton was equivalent to 1,000 tons of high explosive. The uranium bomb used on Hiroshima was estimated at between eleven and a half and thirteen and a half kilotons; the plutonium bomb dropped on Nagasaki was between twenty and twenty-four kilotons. The thermonuclear warheads and bombs on SAC's missiles and bombers and the US Navy's Polaris missiles had explosive yields measured in megatons. Each megaton was equivalent to one million tons of high explosive. The total yield of all the explosives used in World War Two was just over two megatons.

Megadeaths

As noted, some 70-80,000 people died immediately in Hiroshima, rising to 140,000 by the end of 1945, and 200,000 by 1950. Some 30-40,000 people died immediately in Nagasaki, rising to 70,000 by the end of 1945, and 140,000 by 1950. These casualties, though shocking, should be set in the context of the allied bomber offensives against Germany and Japan. When